The Didache: A First-Century Discipleship Manual and Local Church Guide

Framing: The Didache and the Word of God

- **What It Is:** *Didache* (DID-ah-kay) means "Teaching." Its full title is *The Teaching of the Lord to the Gentiles by the Twelve Apostles*. It is one of the earliest Christian writings outside the New Testament.
- **What It Is Not:** It is not inspired Scripture. It is a valuable historical witness to what early assemblies believed and practiced. Where it agrees with the Bible, it confirms that the doctrine was held from the beginning. Where it goes beyond the Bible, the Bible remains the final authority.
  - *KJV anchor:* 2 Timothy 3:16–17; Isaiah 8:20
- **Translation Note:** Quotations in this lesson are drawn from public-domain English translations (Roberts-Donaldson and Lightfoot).

I. Origins, Time, and Location

- **Historical Timeline:** Written between **70 and 110 AD**. The document completely lacks any mention of a regional hierarchy, localized popes, or a multi-tiered priesthood. This establishes an early post-apostolic date, operating within a decentralized network of autonomous assemblies.
- **The Textual Recovery:** Completely lost to the Western world for centuries until its rediscovery in **1873** by Philotheos Bryennios within the *Codex Hierosolymitanus* (copied in 1056 AD by "Leon the Notary"), and published in 1883. Physical 4th-century papyrus fragments matching the text were later excavated in Oxyrhynchus, Egypt, confirming its ancient origin and reliable transmission.
- **Geographical Context:** Internal clues—such as a specific prayer thanking God for grain scattered "upon the mountains" (9:4)—strongly point to **Syria or Palestine** as the region of compilation.

II. Section I: The Two Ways (Chapters 1–6)

- **The Discipleship Purpose:** This opening section is structured as a foundational moral lesson designed for newly confessed converts coming straight out of paganism, grounding them in righteousness before they were brought into the local church body.
  - *KJV anchor:* Jeremiah 21:8; Matthew 7:13–14
- **The Way of Life (Chapters 1–4):** A practical application of the Ten Commandments and Christ's direct teachings from the Sermon on the Mount, adapted to a cosmopolitan Roman environment.
  - *The Double Love Commandment and Golden Rule:* `“The way of life, then, is this: First, you shall love God who made you; second, love your neighbor as yourself; and all things whatsoever you would not should be done to you, do not also to another.” (1:2)`
    - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 22:37–39; Matthew 7:12
  - *Active Non-Resistance and Radical Giving:* `“If any one give thee a blow on thy right cheek, turn to him the other also, and thou shalt be perfect... Give to every one that asks thee, and ask it not back; for the Father wills that to all should be given of our own blessings.” (1:4-5)`
    - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 5:39–42; Luke 6:30
  - *Pragmatic Accountability in Stewardship:* `“But concerning this also it hath been said, Let thine alms sweat in thy hands, until thou know to whom thou shouldst give.” (1:6)`
    - *KJV anchor:* 2 Thessalonians 3:10; 1 Timothy 5:3–8
  - *Explicit Prohibitions Against Abortion and Infanticide:* Built directly upon the Old Testament commandment against murder and the prohibition of passing children through the fire to Molech, explicitly applied to contemporary Roman culture: `“Thou shalt not murder a child by abortion nor kill that which is begotten.” (2:2)`
    - *KJV anchor:* Exodus 20:13; Leviticus 18:21; Psalm 139:13–16
  - *Sins of the Tongue and Heart:* `“Thou shalt not be double-minded nor double-tongued; for to be double-tongued is a snare of death. Thy speech shall not be false, nor empty, but fulfilled by deed.” (2:4-5)`
    - *KJV anchor:* James 1:8; James 3:8–10; Proverbs 18:21
  - *Superstition, Sorcery, and Idolatry:* Echoing the Old Testament prophets and Paul's epistles, the text mocks the nonsensical nature of dead wood and metal, warning

that superstitious practices directly invite demonic deception and idolatry: `“My child, be not an observer of omens, since it leads the way to idolatry; neither an enchanter, nor an astrologer, nor a purifier, nor be willing to look at these things; for from all these idolatry is begotten.” (3:4)`

- *KJV anchor:* Deuteronomy 18:10–12; Isaiah 44:9–20; 1 Corinthians 10:19–20

- **The Way of Death (Chapter 5):** A stark binary contrast listing the vices and characteristics of the unregenerate. This aligns with the biblical realities of the *Tares among the Wheat* and the *Sheep and the Goats*, illustrating that in professing communities, false professors walk alongside true believers until they are tested and revealed.
  - *The Full Catalog of Vices:* `“And the way of death is this: First of all it is evil and full of curse; murders, adulteries, lusts, fornications, thefts, idolatries, witchcrafts, sorceries, robberies, false witnessings, hypocrisies, double-heartedness, deceit, pride, malice, self-will, avarice, filthy talking, jealousy, insolence, arrogance, boasting...” (5:1)`
    - *KJV anchor:* Galatians 5:19–21; Matthew 13:24–30
  - *Characteristics of False Professors:* `“Persecutors of the good, hating truth, loving a lie, not knowing a reward for righteousness, not cleaving to good nor to righteous judgment, watching not for that which is good, but for that which is evil; from whom meekness and endurance are far, loving vanities, pursuing revenge, not pitying a poor man, not laboring for the afflicted...” (5:2)`
    - *KJV anchor:* 2 Timothy 3:1–5; Matthew 25:31–46
- **The Yoke of Maturity (Chapter 6):** A gracious, pastoral recognition that babes in Christ develop at different paces: `“For if thou art able to bear the whole yoke of the Lord, thou wilt be perfect; but if thou art not able, what thou art able that do.” (6:2)` It includes the strict Jerusalem Council restriction against eating meat sacrificed to idols: `“And concerning food, bear what thou art able; but against that which is sacrificed to idols be exceedingly on thy guard; for it is a service of dead gods.” (6:3)`
  - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 11:29–30; 1 Peter 2:2; Acts 15:28–29

III. Section II: Ordinances and Liturgical Order (Chapters 7–10)

- **Believer's Baptism (Chapter 7):** Fits the historic Baptist distinctive of believer's baptism following clear conversion and instruction.
  - *The Trinitarian Formula:* Mandates the formula of Matthew 28:19: `“And concerning baptism, thus baptize ye: Having first said all these things, baptize into the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit, in living water.” (7:1)` Note the phrase "having first said all these things": the Two Ways teaching came *before* baptism.
    - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 28:19–20; Acts 8:36–38
  - *The Order of Preference for Water:* The text lays out a descending order: first, "living" (running) water such as a river or stream; then, "other" (still) water such as a pool; cold before warm. Only when there is not enough water of any kind to baptize in does it permit pouring water three times on the head. Pouring is therefore a last-resort exception for scarcity, not an equal alternative, and the fact that it needed an exception at all shows that going *into* the water was the normal practice: `“But if thou hast not living water, baptize into other water; and if thou canst not in cold, in warm. But if thou hast not either, pour out water thrice upon the head into the name of Father and Son and Holy Spirit.” (7:2-3)`
    - *KJV anchor:* Mark 1:9–10; John 3:23; Romans 6:3–4
  - *Exclusion of Infant Baptism via Fasting:* By requiring that the candidate fast for one or two days prior to the ordinance, the text assumes a conscious, confessing believer who has been taught and can fast; it gives no place for infant baptism: `“And before the baptism let the baptizer fast, and the baptized, and whatever others can; but thou shalt command the baptized to fast one or two days before.” (7:4)`
    - *KJV anchor:* Acts 2:41; Acts 8:12
- **Fasting and Prayer Routines (Chapter 8):**
  - *Separation from Judaizers:* Intentionally shifts fasting days to Wednesdays and Fridays to maintain a clear line of separation from the local Jewish synagogue schedules (Mondays and Thursdays): `“But let not your fasts be with the hypocrites; for they fast on the second and fifth day of the week; but fast ye on the fourth day and the Preparation (Friday).” (8:1)`
    - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 6:16–18; Luke 18:12

- *The Model Prayer and Frequency:* Dictates the exact text of the Lord's Prayer to be prayed three times a day. For babes in Christ, this established a structured habit of prayer, while spacing it throughout the day explicitly prevented the continuous, mindless "vain repetitions" characteristic of pagan concerts and heathen incantations: `“Neither pray ye as the hypocrites, but as the Lord commanded in His Gospel, thus pray ye... Thrice in the day pray ye thus.” (8:2-3)`
  - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 6:5–13; Daniel 6:10; Psalm 55:17

- **The Thanksgiving Feast / Eucharist (Chapters 9–10):**
  - *The Worshipful Corporate Meal:* Dictates prayers for a worshipful communal meal focused entirely on thanksgiving (*eucharistia*). Chapter 10 opens "after ye are filled," indicating a full meal, much like the love feasts of the early church.
    - *KJV anchor:* Acts 2:46; 1 Corinthians 11:20–26; Jude 12
  - *The Cup and the Vine of David:* `“Now concerning the Thanksgiving (Eucharist), thus give thanks. First, concerning the cup: We thank thee, our Father, for the holy vine of David Thy servant, which Thou madest known to us through Jesus Thy Servant; to Thee be the glory for ever.” (9:1-2)`
    - *KJV anchor:* John 15:1–5; Isaiah 11:1
  - *The Broken Bread: Life, Knowledge, and One Church Gathered:* The prayer over the bread gives thanks for "the life and knowledge" made known through Jesus (9:3). It then uses the grain as a picture: just as wheat scattered across the hillsides is harvested and baked into one loaf, so the Lord's people, scattered throughout the world, will be gathered into His one kingdom. The emphasis is on unity and future gathering, not on any change in the bread itself. Notably, the prayers as preserved say nothing about the bread or cup becoming Christ's body and blood: `“Even as this broken bread was scattered over the hills, and was gathered together and became one, so let Thy Church be gathered together from the ends of the earth into Thy kingdom...” (9:4)`
    - *KJV anchor:* 1 Corinthians 10:17; John 11:52; Matthew 24:31
  - *Fencing the Table:* Strictly restricts participation to baptized believers, explicitly applying Christ's warning from Matthew 7:6: `“But let no one eat or drink of your Thanksgiving (Eucharist), but they who have been baptized into the`

`name of the Lord; for concerning this also the Lord hath said: Give not that which is holy to the dogs.” (9:5)`

- *KJV anchor:* Matthew 7:6; 1 Corinthians 11:27–29

- *The Concluding Eschatological Cry:* `“Let grace come, and let this world pass away. Hosanna to the God of David! If any one is holy, let him come; if any one is not so, let him repent. Maranatha! Amen.” (10:6)`
  - *KJV anchor:* 1 Corinthians 16:22; Revelation 22:17, 20

IV. Section III: Local Church Structure and Governance (Chapters 11–15)

- **Vetting Traveling Preachers (Chapter 11):** Provides a direct, plain-language behavioral checklist to protect the church from financial exploitation and heretical "itching ears" without a centralized denominational headquarters.
  - *The Doctrinal Standard:* `“Whosoever, therefore, cometh and teacheth you all these things that have been said before, receive him. But if the teacher himself turn aside and teach another teaching to the destruction of this, hear him not.” (11:1-2)`
    - *KJV anchor:* Galatians 1:8–9; 2 John 10; 2 Timothy 4:3
  - *Time Limits on Travelers:* `“And every apostle that cometh to you let him be received as the Lord. But he shall not remain except one day; but if there be need, also the next; but if he remain three days, he is a false prophet.” (11:4-5)`
  - *Financial Red Flags and True Prophecy:* "Speaking in the Spirit" is defined as delivering intelligible, scriptural discourse. The text explicitly links false manifestations to greed and lifestyle corruption: `“And when the apostle goeth away let him take nothing but bread until he lodgeth; but if he ask money, he is a false prophet... And every prophet that speaketh in the Spirit ye shall not try nor judge... but not every one that speaketh in the Spirit is a prophet, but only if he holds the behavior of the Lord.” (11:6-8)`
    - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 7:15–20; 1 John 4:1; 2 Peter 2:3
  - *The Financial Preaching Warning:* `“And whosoever shall say in the Spirit: Give me money, or any other things, ye shall not hear him; but if he tell you to give for others that are in need, let no one judge him.” (11:12)`

    - *KJV anchor:* 1 Timothy 6:5; Acts 20:33–35

- **The Christ-Peddler Warning (Chapter 12):** Traveling ordinary Christians who wish to settle permanently must work, guarding the church against idleness: `“But if he who cometh wishes to settle among you, and is a craftsman, let him work and eat. But if he has no craft, according to your wisdom provide how he shall live as a Christian among you, but not in idleness. But if he will not act thus, he is a Christ-peddler (Christemporos). Beware of such.” (12:2-5)`
    - *KJV anchor:* 2 Thessalonians 3:6–12; 2 Corinthians 2:17

- **Supporting Those Who Minister: The Laborer Is Worthy (Chapter 13):** Having just warned against freeloaders, the text now balances the scale. A true prophet or teacher who settles to minister among the church *is* to be supported, as a laborer is worthy of his food. This is the same principle Paul draws from the law of the ox: "Thou shalt not muzzle the ox that treadeth out the corn."
    - *Worthy of His Food:* `“But every true prophet that wills to abide among you is worthy of his support. So also a true teacher is himself worthy, as the workman, of his support.” (13:1-2)`
        - *KJV anchor:* Deuteronomy 25:4; 1 Corinthians 9:7–14; 1 Timothy 5:17–18; Matthew 10:10
    - *Giving the Firstfruits:* The church is commanded to give the *first and best* of every kind of increase, from the farm, the kitchen, the purse, and the closet, to support those who minister. The text calls this giving "according to the commandment," tying it directly to the Old Testament pattern of firstfruits and tithes that supported the Levites: `“Every first-fruit, therefore, of the products of wine-press and threshing-floor, of oxen and of sheep, you shall take and give to the prophets, for they are your high priests... If you make a batch of dough, take the first-fruit and give according to the commandment. So also when you open a jar of wine or of oil, take the first-fruit and give it to the prophets; and of money (silver) and clothing and every possession, take the first-fruit, as it may seem good to you, and give according to the commandment.” (13:3, 5-7)`
        - *KJV anchor:* Proverbs 3:9–10; Malachi 3:10; Numbers 18:21; Nehemiah 10:35–37
    - *A Note on "Your High Priests":* The phrase describes the *role* the Levitical priests once held as recipients of firstfruits, not a priestly office in the church. The New

Testament teaches the priesthood of every believer, with Christ alone as our High Priest.
        - *KJV anchor:* Hebrews 4:14; 1 Peter 2:9
    - *Giving to the Poor:* When there is no resident minister to support, the firstfruits are not kept back; they go to the poor: `“But if you have no prophet, give it to the poor.” (13:4)`
        - *KJV anchor:* Galatians 2:10; Proverbs 19:17
- **Horizontal Confession and Local Dispute Resolution (Chapter 14):** Confession is defined strictly as an interpersonal reconciliation between brothers to resolve a local dispute before entering corporate worship, completely rejecting any sacramental penance to an intermediary priest: `“But on the Lord's Day do ye assemble and break bread, and give thanks, after having confessed your transgressions, that your sacrifice may be pure. But let every one that hath a dispute with his fellow not assemble with you, until they be reconciled, that your sacrifice be not defiled.” (14:1-2)`
    - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 5:23–24; James 5:16; Hebrews 13:15
- **The Two Offices of the Local Assembly (Chapter 15):** Explicitly mirrors the New Testament and Baptist distinctive of only two local offices: **bishops** (pastors/overseers) and **deacons**.
    - *Congregational Appointment and Local Autonomy:* The text mandates independent congregational choice: `“Appoint, therefore, for yourselves, bishops and deacons worthy of the Lord, men meek, and not lovers of money, and truthful and proven; for they also render to you the ministry of prophets and teachers.” (15:1)` The choice lies entirely with the local membership. No outside bishop, synod, or headquarters appoints them; each assembly governs itself.
        - *KJV anchor:* Philippians 1:1; Acts 6:3–5; 1 Timothy 3:1–13
    - *Loving Reproof:* `“And reprove one another, not in anger, but in peace, as ye have it in the Gospel...” (15:3)`
        - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 18:15–17; Galatians 6:1

V. Section IV: Primitive Eschatology (Chapter 16)

A. What the Text Explicitly Says

- **A Note on the Manuscript:** The only complete manuscript breaks off mid-thought at 16:8, right after the Lord is seen coming on the clouds. Whatever followed (likely judgment and reward) is lost. We must be careful not to build on what isn't there.
- *The Watchfulness Directive:* `“Watch for your life's sake. Let not your lamps be quenched, nor your loins unloosed; but be ye ready, for ye know not the hour in which our Lord cometh.” (16:1)`
  - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 25:1–13; Luke 12:35–40
- *Gather Often, Finish Well:* `“But often shall ye come together, seeking the things which are befitting to your souls: for the whole time of your faith will not profit you, if ye be not made complete in the last time.” (16:2)`
  - *KJV anchor:* Hebrews 10:25; Matthew 24:13
- *Last-Days Apostasy:* `“For in the last days false prophets and corrupters shall be multiplied, and the sheep shall be turned into wolves, and love shall be turned into hate; for when lawlessness increaseth, they shall hate and persecute and betray one another.” (16:3-4a)`
  - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 24:10–12; 2 Timothy 3:1–5
- *The Church Endures the Antichrist:* Believers are explicitly warned that they will face the deceptions and global power of the final world-deceiver: `“And then shall appear the world-deceiver as Son of God, and shall do signs and wonders, and the earth shall be delivered into his hands, and he shall do iniquitous things which have never yet come to pass since the beginning.” (16:4)`
  - *KJV anchor:* 2 Thessalonians 2:3–4, 9; Revelation 13:7–8; Matthew 24:21
- *The Fiery Trial of Separation:* This severe tribulation under the persecution of man acts as the great sifter of the professing community. Vain professors who went through the motions will stumble and perish, while true believers will be revealed and preserved through endurance: `“Then shall the creation of men come into the fire of trial, and many shall be stumbled and shall perish; but they that endure in their faith shall be saved by the Curse itself.” (16:5)`
  - *"Saved by the Curse Itself":* A puzzling phrase. The most common understanding is that "the Curse" refers to Christ, who was made a curse for us. Some translators render it "saved *from* the curse."
  - *KJV anchor:* Galatians 3:13; 1 Peter 4:12; Matthew 24:13

- *The Signs, the Trumpet, and the Resurrection of the Saints:* Christ's return is a singular, public, audible, and visual event introduced by a trumpet blast, and it comes *after* the world-deceiver's reign and the fiery trial: `“And then shall appear the signs of the truth; first, the sign of an outspreading in heaven; then the sign of the sound of the trumpet; and the third, the resurrection of the dead; yet not of all, but as it was said: The Lord shall come and all His saints with Him. Then shall the world see the Lord coming upon the clouds of heaven.” (16:6-8)`
    - *KJV anchor:* Matthew 24:29–31; 1 Thessalonians 4:16–17; 1 Corinthians 15:51–52; Zechariah 14:5

B. The Sequence Stated in the Text

1. Apostasy and false prophets multiply
2. The world-deceiver appears, rules the earth, and persecutes
3. The fiery trial: false professors fall away, true believers endure
4. Signs in heaven, then the trumpet
5. The resurrection of the dead, but only of the saints ("not of all")
6. The Lord comes on the clouds, visible to the whole world

- **Post-Tribulation Gathering:** The church is present through the world-deceiver's reign, and the trumpet and resurrection of the saints come *after* it. This is the order the text itself gives, matching Matthew 24:29–31 ("immediately after the tribulation of those days... a great sound of a trumpet... gather together his elect").
- **The Future Antichrist and Visible Return:** These are presented as still to come, not as events already fulfilled.

C. Reasonable Inferences

- **Pre-Wrath:** The trial in 16:5 is the "fire of trial" among men, persecution by the world-deceiver, not the outpouring of God's wrath. The saints are raised at the trumpet before the world sees the Lord coming in judgment. God's wrath itself is not described in the surviving text (likely in the lost ending), so the pre-wrath framing is the natural reading of the sequence, though the wrath portion is less detailed.
    - *KJV anchor:* 1 Thessalonians 1:10; 1 Thessalonians 5:9; Revelation 6:16–17
- **A Separate, Later Resurrection of the Unsaved:** "Not of all" means some of the dead are not raised at this time. Read alongside Scripture, this fits a first resurrection of the

saints and a later resurrection of the rest before the Great White Throne.
    - *KJV anchor:* Revelation 20:4–6, 11–15; John 5:28–29
- **A Future Kingdom:** The Didache never mentions a thousand-year reign. But it prays for the Church to be gathered "into Thy kingdom" (9:4, 10:5) and for "this world [to] pass away" (10:6). The kingdom is something still awaited, which is consistent with a future millennial kingdom.
    - *KJV anchor:* Revelation 20:4; Matthew 6:10; Acts 1:6–7

D. Comparison with Modern Views

View	How It Fares Against Didache 16
Preterism (fulfilled in 70 AD)	Conflicts directly: the world-deceiver, trumpet, and resurrection are all future.
Postmillennialism (world improves before Christ returns)	Conflicts: the world grows worse—apostasy, lawlessness, and a global deceiver—until the end.
Amillennialism (no literal future kingdom; one general resurrection)	Strained: "not of all" sits awkwardly with a single general resurrection.
Pre-Tribulation Rapture (church removed before the Antichrist)	Conflicts: the church is explicitly warned that it will face the world-deceiver and the fiery trial.
Post-Tribulation / Pre-Wrath Premillennialism	Fits the stated sequence most naturally.

Deck Build Notes

- **Two Card Styles:** Didache quotations on parchment-style cards; KJV cross-references in gold tap-to-reveal verse modals, so the class always sees which is Scripture and which is commentary.
- **Chapter 16 Layout:** Use visibly different treatments for "Explicitly Stated" and "Reasonable Inference," and present the sequence as a numbered timeline.

- **Seven-Section Map:** (1) Framing, (2) Origins, (3) The Two Ways, (4) Ordinances, (5) Church Order incl. ch. 13, (6) Last Things, (7) Application & Maranatha (closing on 10:6).